Inspection of Wokingham local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 21 September 2026 to 2 October 2026

Lead inspector: Claire Beckingham, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	**Grade**
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Good
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Requires improvement to be good

Leaders in Wokingham Borough Council have largely succeeded in breaking a long history of underperformance and have transformed practice so that most children now receive a strong service.

The majority of children in need of help and protection receive a considered and consistent response that is helping reduce risks to them and improve their lives. This includes notable strengths in responding to stubborn, complex and generational forms of harm, such as neglect, domestic abuse and child sexual abuse. Well-established tracking and monitoring arrangements help to ensure momentum and focus for children.

The experiences of children in care are particularly well developed, with the council's approach to corporate parenting evident from first line practice to strategic and political leadership. Children in care are listened to. They are celebrated and they are valued. Independent reviewing officers (IROs) stand out for championing issues important to children and ensuring that children's care plans progress at pace.

The quality of support for care leavers has been affected by staffing instability in a small service. Consequently, the experiences of care leavers are polarised. For those care leavers who have experienced an enduring relationship with their personal adviser (PA), support is responsive and highly attuned to their needs. Other care

leavers have experienced inconsistent relationships and delays in receiving help and support. Plans and measures to strengthen the service were underway before this inspection.

What needs to improve?[1]

- Staff capacity in the care-leavers service to promote consistency of experiences and support for care leavers. (outcome 4, national framework)
- Frequency of visits to care leavers in line with need. (outcome 4, national framework)
- Care leavers being consulted in decisions to step back from the service. (outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children in Wokingham receive effective help and protection. Multi-agency working, high-quality child protection practice, skilled responses to domestic abuse and meaningful direct work contribute to improved safety and progress for most children. For a very small number of children referred to the multi-agency safeguarding hub (MASH), timeliness and management oversight needs to be strengthened.

2. Most children receive the right level of help when it is needed, whether that is through Family Help (targeted early help) or referral to children's social care. Family Help is successfully improving children's experiences and strengthening family relationships for many children.

3. Overall, MASH provides an effective service for children. Work undertaken with partners has resulted in referrals that are detailed, specific and focused on children's lived experiences. Management direction and oversight is usually thorough and appropriate. Consideration of fathers and wider family networks is not consistently embedded within MASH practice. For a small number of children, work is not completed within the expected timescales. Where delays occur, management oversight does not consistently explain the reasons for these delays or demonstrate an active review of risk. For a very small number of children, the initial analysis and grading of risk at the front door did not correlate to the subsequent assessment and intervention that was taken for the child. Leaders were already strengthening work in the MASH at the time of inspection.

[1] The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the Children's Social Care: National Framework. This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

4. When children are discussed at child protection strategy discussions, this is usually prompt and proportionate to risk. Multi-agency information supports collective analysis of risks, strengths and likely future harm. Safety planning is considered early and is proportionate in managing immediate risk. Child protection enquiries are an area of particular strength, with decisions that are clear, child-focused and supported by compelling analysis. Enquiries demonstrate professional curiosity, involve children and families appropriately and make use of partner agency information. The quality of enquiry, assessment and analysis supports safeguarding planning and improves children's safety.

5. Most children receive high-quality assessments of their needs that are comprehensive and informed by meaningful multi-agency contributions. Most assessments demonstrate that the family's cultural differences are respectfully understood and responded to. Practice demonstrates sensitivity, curiosity and an educative approach, recognising how parents' own cultural experiences and upbringing influence their parenting practices. Children's voices are mostly evident, with strengths and risks analysed well to inform targeted planning.

6. Children supported through child in need plans are routinely seen alone and their experiences are reflected in planning. Most plans are tailored to individual need and reviewed regularly through detailed supervision. Closure planning is thoughtful and gradual. The quality of support is helping families sustain progress. For a small number of children, decisions are not fully explained and the rationale for continuing or ending intervention is insufficiently recorded.

7. Child protection work is a clear strength in Wokingham. The use and decision-making of child protection conferences are proportionate to risk. Children are encouraged and supported to participate, records are accessible and planning is focused on reducing risk. Child protection plans are generally well written, specific and adapted to changing circumstances. They are reviewed regularly by the family and professional network, with multi-agency contributions clearly captured. This is helping to make children's lives better. When children are subject to repeat child protection planning, this is appropriate. For a very small number of families, decision-making to end plans is over optimistic. However, the majority benefit from well-considered moves into child in need arrangements, helping to ensure that progress is maintained and risks continue to be monitored. Family group decision-making for children subject to plans is evident and increasing in scope. For most children, when child protection planning is not reducing risks, progression into pre-proceedings and care proceedings is swift when required.

8. Practice relating to domestic abuse, physical abuse, neglect and sexual abuse is robust. Practitioners demonstrate confidence in recognising and naming harm and provide proportionate, child-focused responses. Domestic abuse work is well developed. Survivors are routinely spoken to alone, their experiences inform decision-making and safety planning is comprehensive. Practitioners work with housing, probation and specialist services to improve family safety.

Responses to physical abuse are quick and proportionate, including strategy discussions, child protection enquiries, direct work with children and comprehensive safety planning. Practice demonstrates sensitivity when exploring parenting, culture, family dynamics and the impact of harm on children. Where neglect is identified, practitioners use assessment tools to understand the impact on children's daily lives. Children are seen regularly, risks are monitored and escalation occurs where concerns persist. Practice regarding sexual abuse is particularly strong. Practitioners are confident in identifying concerns, explicit about risk and demonstrate empathy and professionalism when working with children, non-abusing parents and alleged perpetrators. Reflective supervision supports high-quality analysis and decision-making.

9. Children at risk of exploitation benefit from swift identification, assessment and intervention. The Compass Team provides intensive support informed by trauma, attachment and neurodiversity. Multi-agency arrangements are effective. However, for a small number of children experiencing long-term exploitation, the pace and intensity of intervention do not fully match their needs.

10. Disabled children benefit from comprehensive assessments of their needs, coordinated planning and strong advocacy. Short break services provide valuable support, and transitions into adulthood are generally well planned.

11. Arrangements for private fostering and homeless 16- or 17-year-old children are well established. Work relating to young carers is less developed. While leaders have identified this and established plans to strengthen arrangements, there remains limited evidence of impact and insufficient assurance that young carers consistently receive the support they need.

12. The commissioned Emergency Duty Service provides an effective out-of-hours response. Staff demonstrate professional curiosity, gather information from a range of sources and produce clear records that support decision-making. Information is transferred promptly to daytime services and transitions between services are seamless.

13. Local authority designated officer decisions are appropriate. However, systems, processes and recording lack sufficient rigour to provide a clear audit trail and accountability. This has already been identified by leaders, and a new system is being implemented.

14. Children who are electively home educated, and those missing education, are monitored by meticulous processes and routines that support timely contact with families at key points and when intelligence indicates that children are at risk. Leaders are well sighted on who their vulnerable children are.

The experiences and progress of children in care: outstanding

15. Children enter care at the right time, when this intervention is proportionate to risk and after support has been provided to parents and carers to enable them to continue caring for their children safely at home wherever possible. Decision-making is informed by a clear understanding of children's needs, wishes and lived experiences, and children in care are supported to make significant progress. The children that inspectors met spoke of the many positive experiences they had in care and especially praised the virtual school. Participation is a real strength, and children speak highly about the work they do. They feel heard and empowered. They know they are part of making positive change for all children in Wokingham and they enjoy the opportunities to get together and complete this work.

16. Social worker visits to children are regular, purposeful and at a frequency determined by need. Practitioners work with care, compassion and sensitivity, using direct work tools confidently to elicit children's views and to support them to navigate changes in their lives. Direct tools are also used effectively and thoughtfully when working with disabled children including non-verbal children. Practitioners become incredibly animated when talking about children. They know the children exceptionally well, and the sense of pride and joy they express about children can be felt and seen.

17. Social worker update assessments for child in care reviews are detailed and comprehensive. Reviews are well planned, and children are actively encouraged and supported to participate. The use of advocacy and independent visitors is very well embedded, and children's views are valued across the service.

18. Care planning includes regular management oversight, and most care plans progress very well. In the minority of situations where plans drift or a delay is identified, IROs provide appropriate challenges through formal escalation processes.

19. Children benefit from exceptionally well-managed permanence tracking systems, with senior management oversight to ensure that all available permanency options are considered at the earliest juncture. Social workers work collaboratively and sensitively with children and their families to explore all available options and secure permanence for children swiftly.

20. Most children in care live in or near to Wokingham. When they are out of the area, they are in homes that meet their needs and where their workers visit them regularly. Children are carefully matched with carers who can meet their cultural, religious and identity needs, helping children to maintain a sense of belonging, stability and wellbeing. This is often with adults from within the children's own network, and the use of family network meetings is helping to identify, and support, connected carers early.

21. Permanency through Special Guardianship Orders (SGOs) is considered at an early stage and, when this is right for children, it is progressed through regular management oversight, including supervision, placement planning meetings and legal tracking. Assessments are comprehensive and respond to the child's current and emerging needs. SGO support plans are comprehensive, dynamic documents that are reviewed regularly and include a wide range of support for children, carers and wider family members. Plans are well coordinated and make good use of commissioned services, local support groups and advocacy organisations.

22. Where placements are at risk of breaking down, practitioners make every effort to support carers and to repair relationships through appropriate intervention and support, which is contributing to positive placement stability.

23. The professional network works together to ensure that children's physical, dental and optical health needs are well met. Therapeutic intervention is accessed appropriately to support children with their mental health. However, children awaiting neurodiversity pathway assessments are subject to long waits of up to 30 months. While leaders continue to work with health partners to address wait times, there is limited mitigation for individual children.

24. Children are supported to access a wide range of social, recreational and developmental activities that reflect their interests and hobbies. Their achievements are recognised and celebrated, and important life events and milestones are acknowledged in a meaningful way.

25. Family time is consistently promoted and regularly reviewed to ensure it remains purposeful, meaningful and flexible to the changing needs of the child and their family. This is maintaining positive relationships and helping children see people who are important to them. Together and apart assessments for brothers and sisters are routinely carried out and carefully consider what support would be needed to support a 'together' outcome.

26. For almost all children, transitions between placements are well planned, with opportunities for children to visit and experience their new home prior to moving.

27. Wokingham currently has no children in unregistered children's homes and has only used these unlawful placements as a very last resort. Where this has happened, it has been with increased oversight and children's wishes and feelings are actively sought and inform planning.

28. Children are successfully reunified with parents when this is safe and in their best interests. Decisions to place children under placement with parent regulations benefit from well-established tracking and oversight of decisions made. Comprehensive assessments determine the suitability of these arrangements and are informed by clear safety plans, which help parents and

connected family members to understand what is required to keep children safe in their care.

29. Children living in supported accommodation are provided with safe and stable housing and are supported to develop the skills required for independent living. For young people who are not yet ready to move into fully independent accommodation, transitional arrangements are in place. These are supported by clearly defined financial and care packages.

30. Children are visited regularly, and their wishes and preferences regarding future accommodation are actively considered as part of pathway planning.

31. Unaccompanied asylum-seeking children are placed in homes where their needs are well met. Use of interpreters is routine for meetings and to explain key documents, and advocacy is encouraged and accessed when accepted. Assessments are detailed and sensitive. Children are referred to specialist support agencies to help them trace family members left behind. Workers are quick to ensure that health needs are well understood.

32. Children in care receive excellent support in education via the virtual school, in addition to the support they receive in their home schools. The highly effective virtual school acts as an experienced, consistent advocate for the children in care. The virtual school is ambitious and underpinned by a moral imperative: 'Is it good enough for my own child? If not, it is not good enough for children we serve.' As a result, attendance and the academic performance of children in care are improving.

33. Fostering and adoption services are led by experienced managers who maintain a focus on achieving positive permanence outcomes for children. Leaders have a good understanding of service performance and use quality assurance processes to drive improvement. Foster carers receive purposeful training, supervision and support, enabling them to meet children's needs and promote stability. The structured support model is a particular strength, providing valuable peer support and enhancing placement stability. Foster carers value the support they receive from supervising social workers and demonstrate commitment to children in their care. Adoption services are child focused and successful in promoting permanence. Prospective adopters benefit from comprehensive preparation and ongoing support, while robust panel and decision-making processes ensure that children's needs remain central to planning.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: requires improvement to be good

34. The overall experience of care leavers in Wokingham is variable. When it is positive, it is very positive, but too many care leavers have had a poor experience. Leaders in Wokingham are not ambivalent corporate parents; they remain ambitious for their care leavers. Leaders fully acknowledged the

variability; they had already apologised to care leavers, and care-leaver voices continue to shape and inform developments in the service. While leaders have acted decisively and have appropriate plans in place, it is too soon to evaluate the full reach and impact of these measures.

35. Most care leavers move towards adulthood at a pace that is right for them. While PAs are introduced early for some children, enabling them to benefit from forming strong early bonds with them, meaningful engagement predominantly starts after care leavers have reached adulthood. This limits opportunities for care leavers to develop a trusting relationship with their worker before becoming an adult and navigating all the challenges, and exciting opportunities, that growing up brings.

36. For those care leavers who have had a consistent PA, many have experienced strong support. These care leavers are supported by PAs who know them exceptionally well. PAs speak about care leavers with genuine pride, warmth and care, demonstrating trusting relationships. However, too many care leavers have had multiple changes of workers, irregular contact from the service and no support around stressful life events. Leaders have worked to re-engage some care leavers, but some care leavers appear to have lost faith.

37. Some care leavers are seen regularly and in line with their individual needs. When it is working well, PAs become important figures in their lives, with care leavers describing them as like a 'friend' or a 'parent'. Some care leavers' records do not always capture the extent of contact, or the depth of the relationship that their PAs have with them. High caseloads are hindering PAs from recording and delivering the level of service they want to. In the last 6 months, care leavers have largely only been visited in line with statutory timescales. Outside of the statutory visits, very little is recorded and, prior to the last 6 months, there are gaps in visiting of many months. A churn in allocation of PAs has created a 'start again' effect that makes it understandably difficult for care leavers to engage.

38. There is a structured 'stepping back' process for care leavers aged over 21. For some care leavers, decisions to step back from PA support are well considered, based on an assessment of their support needs and their own views. For some, when they said they were not ready, this was respected. For others, the decision was made without them being sufficiently involved, which does not give that care leaver a chance to respond to such a big decision about their life. For some care leavers, keeping in touch contact has been infrequent following their 21st birthday, resulting in gaps in communication and support.

39. Some pathway plans are comprehensive, detailed and developed collaboratively with care leavers. For others, multiple changes in PA and inconsistent contact have meant that their pathway plans have not been updated. The local offer is clearly detailed within each pathway plan. Care leavers who are engaged and aware are supported through a wide range of services.

40. Persistent and detailed efforts by experienced staff support care leavers in next steps in education, employment or training (EET). A virtual school EET worker provides targeted support tailored to care leavers' abilities and ambitions. For many care leavers, this means they have access to aspirational and suitable opportunities with local and national employers and at universities. Where young people are not in EET through ill health or poor mental health, care leavers are encouraged to remain ambitious and to have confidence that they can and will achieve.

41. PAs understand care leavers' physical and mental health needs well and seek support and guidance when this is required. Care leavers who are disabled are in supportive placements where it appears their needs are well met. For some disabled care leavers who are supported by adult services, PA work is limited and there have been gaps in visits until recently. For those care leavers with disabilities living independently, PAs assist them to access financial and practical support and explore whether their health needs are being addressed.

42. Strong partnership working with housing services and accommodation providers has led to improved housing options for care leavers. These improvements have increased the availability of suitable accommodation and strengthened support arrangements. Staying put an arrangement that enables care leavers to remain living with foster carers when they turn 18 is actively encouraged. Care leavers have priority housing status. Leaders have increased accommodation options and continue to expand provision.

43. PAs, leaders and the multi-agency partners take appropriate steps to ensure that care leavers are supported to understand, reduce and manage potential exploitation risks. Support around exploitation does not end just because care leavers have reached 18 years old.

44. When care leavers become parents, PAs provide practical and emotional support to help them meet both their own needs and those of their children.

45. Care leavers in custody continue to receive support in line with their age and level of need. There are established processes in place to provide financial support to the wider network to ensure that they are able to see the young people in prison, which helps prevent isolation and maintains those important relationships.

46. The majority of former unaccompanied asylum-seeking children who are now care leavers receive compassionate, high-quality support from PAs who are highly responsive to their individual needs, backgrounds and experiences.

47. Wokingham's initiative of providing later life letters to care leavers is a real strength, enabling care leavers to enter adulthood with a better understanding of their experiences.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: good

48. Children in Wokingham benefit from a stable leadership team with a shared vision for children's services and for all children. A commitment to creating 'a place where everyone can thrive' runs through strategies, ambitions, projects and directorates, with the sense of a whole-council response to the needs of children and families evident. Partnerships with housing, education and the police are mature and engaged. Inspectors identified that some health provision is not yet yielding all that is needed for some children and could see evidence that local authority leaders were seeking to address this. Leaders are proud to be a borough that places reducing inequalities at the heart of its work and has truly grasped that to tackle the root cause of inequality requires a whole-system response.

49. The chief executive, the lead member and the leader of the council all demonstrate dedicated corporate and political ownership of children's services. They each shared a coherent, detailed and enthusiastic account of the numerous workstreams, projects and initiatives in place to improve the lives of children. They are credible, committed corporate parents who are aspirational for children. They, along with senior leaders in children's services, recognised the need for a more consistent response to the needs of care leavers. They are disappointed and self-critical that some care leavers have experienced poor services that are not reflective of their needs. Actions to address the inconsistency are in place.

50. Leaders have created the organisational and political conditions necessary for children to remain a priority, including sustained and increased investment in children's services despite financial challenges. This investment has resulted in the development of children's homes, homes for care leavers, family hubs, the establishment of a family network meeting service, workforce growth, expanding SEND school place provision, and expanding foster care services, to name just some areas investment has transformed. Leaders have achieved closer alignment between children's services, housing and adult social care, by having the right people come together in the right places.

51. Governance arrangements are highly effective, with corporate and elected leaders well sighted on both strategic priorities and operational challenges in children's services. They have cultivated a relationship with the director of children's services, and created an environment where people can be honest, transparent and look for shared solutions to concerns and problems.

52. Wokingham has a comprehensive quality assurance and performance framework that is mature, well embedded and reflective in nature. The combination of core audits, themed work, multi-agency audit activity, practice and outcome meetings, performance dashboards and strategic governance arrangements provide multiple lines of sight into frontline practice. Leaders have an embedded learning culture; they invite external scrutiny and, more

importantly, act quickly on the learning identified. Particularly impressive is the way qualitative learning is brought together with quantitative performance information to support scrutiny and service improvement. The framework is not overly reliant on data alone and demonstrates a genuine focus on learning and continuous improvement. Inspectors did not find any areas of weakness that leaders did not already know about and were not already working on. While not all improvement plans are at the impact stage, they are in the process of implementation.

53. Wokingham is successfully implementing the reforms, steering staff through whole-system change with an exceptionally high degree of engagement and co-design from practitioners. Some children are starting to keep social workers from assessment through to being children in care and are benefiting from less transition points under the new model.

54. Partner agencies, including schools, the Designated Family Judge and Cafcass, are positive about Wokingham, citing collaboration and improving timeliness and appropriate plans for children.

55. Practitioners are overwhelmingly positive about the leadership team. Overall, workers spoke about manageable workloads, with a notable exception being the care leavers service. Social workers completing their assessed and supported year of employment (ASYE) value the support via the academy, the learning offer and support from direct managers. Practitioners across services praise the learning offer and speak about how it contributes to their wellbeing and confidence. The principal social worker and social work academy are undertaking work that is having a tangible impact on the lives of children, particularly through the life-story and later life work.

56. Workers from global majority backgrounds described an inclusive culture where difference is celebrated and promoted. Wokingham's workforce strategy is successfully increasing the permanent workforce, reducing turnover and increasing retention of social workers in their ASYE. While turnover is reducing, Wokingham is small and relatively small changes have a big impact.

57. Supervision is largely an area of strength across services and is bolstered by additional senior management oversight when needed.

58. At the outset of this inspection, leaders spoke about the very last line of the last Ofsted judgement report: 'Children in receipt of services and care leavers do not sufficiently influence the way in which services are designed and developed.' In the 3 years since the last inspection, leaders and practitioners appear to have taken this message as a personal challenge, and co-production now runs through the core of services. Leaders are rightly proud of their participation offer, as are children and care leavers, who could give multiple examples of how they shape and change services.

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